

Securing our imminent future



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"An E-United Nations will go a long way to make security of the Net a crucial responsibility for every participating nation state – not just incumbent upon businesses and employees, as things stand right now."

Technology is advancing at a great pace. As life gets more convenient, and getting things done is easier than ever, we start depending on the Internet far more than we spare a thought. Searching for information, socializing, planning travels, vacations, even filtering down to the most basic of communications (be it for work or pleasure) to donating your PC's time through complicated, state-of-the-art distributed computing for unlocking our universe's greatest mysteries – we're doing all of this and more, thanks to the Internet. Naturally, security of the Internet's infrastructure, and of the systems critical to our daily lives, becomes increasingly important (if nothing else) for one big reason. Cybercrime.

If you're getting something for free, then you're the product – we all know that. For cybercriminals, free online services are like neatly wrapped presents left under the Christmas tree, waiting to be opened and enjoyed. If something's free, they'll find a way to abuse it. Free webmail accounts, cloud storage services, dynamic DNS services, free social networks, email to SMS gateways, domain registrations are being exploited by criminals and malware architects to push online crime to an all-time high, testing systems to their limits. A combination of brute force and human error lead to an inevitable breach.

Attacks of the kind that happened on Sony Entertainment last December are exceptions, because they become a part of public discourse (movie, North Korea, terrorism, so many topics to keep hacks like us busy). The worrying nature of cybercrime is not just in its rampant rise across a broad sector of our industries (connected online) – healthcare, government, corporations, banking and finance, information and telecom, insurance sector – but most business' and organizations' ineptitude to deal with data breaches. Most function without an exhaustive information security policy. More worrying is the thought of infiltrating entities being largely undetected for a substantial amount of time (sometime ranging up to several months, which was the case in the Sony hack) in breached systems, and the business community's reticence towards proactively admitting successful hack attacks (to protect their brand image and market valuation). All this leaves ordinary citizens – people like you and me – increasingly vulnerable. Not a happy place to be.

Why should we care? Because at stake is not just our bank balance, our identity, but also our

online freedom, a basic sense of privacy and trust we tend to expect from the Internet. Will anyone login to any online service if you're constantly suspicious of it? No, right? Now imagine that for most of the things you care about online.

If Hollywood studios (protected by DMCA, MPAA, etc), financial institutions, and sensitive government departments of the US can be breached and hacked into, it's safe to assume that nothing's safe online. Ultimately, laws have to be stricter, and governments have to do more.

Europe is taking the lead on data security and protecting private information online, by enforcing mandatory breach disclosure, data protection policies, and hefty fines (between €100 million or 5% of annual revenue, according to some reports) on online businesses to protect online data within the European Union as early as 2016. The US is in the process of applying the finishing touches to a comprehensive cyber security framework as well. But the EU is only protecting Europeans, US laws only protect Americans. While India's still far behind the big boys on issues concerning cyber security and Internet governance, I can't help but think that an international law protecting the privacy of everyone online is crucial to safeguard us, our data, and our infrastructure.

We can't just have bilateral collaborations (or investigations) on a case-to-case basis while taking down online bad guys in a coordinated effort. As a global resource, the Internet needs to be democratized and decentralized, that much is clear. To that effect, an E-United Nations will go a long way to make security of the Net a crucial responsibility for every participating nation state – not just incumbent upon businesses and employees, as things stand right now.

Sure, we need to hone our online security senses, be extra careful, just like we do while safeguarding our house or while driving a car in a downpour. But we'll make mistakes, we're only human. Online entities that we interact with and the law of the land need to aim at higher standards than us; to preserve and maintain our trust of a safe and secure Internet for all of us. 